



BAKED CUSTARD TARTS

pastéis de nata

MAKES 24 PASTRIES

The reigning monarch of desserts in Lisbon and, frankly, in all of Portugal, is the *pastél de nata*, or custard tart, the most famous of which can be found in only one place: the Antiga Confeitaria de Belém, on the outskirts of the capital city. Once a sundries shop, the *confeitaria* was converted to a bakery in the early 1800s, and the pastries have been made there ever since. The *pastéis*, rich custard encased in crisp, frilly pastry cups, are served warm with a generous sprinkling of confectioners' sugar and cinnamon.

Everything about the pastries is a secret. During all my "official" visits, trying to suss out the recipe, I was carefully steered away from the vault, behind whose locked doors the elements—tree-trunk-thick logs of puff pastry and the custard—are made. While not "official," this recipe draws upon what I learned, letting me use ingredients and techniques available to the home cook. And it's pretty tasty, too.

ATENÇÃO 🍴 Pastéis de nata are made in individual $\frac{1}{3}$ -cup forms (see Sources, page 251), which give them their characteristic size and shape and make them eons easier to shape than if made in a muffin tin. If you use a muffin tin (newer ones have a $\frac{1}{2}$ -cup capacity), simply press the dough as far up the wells as possible.

ONE $1\frac{1}{4}$ -OUNCE PACKAGE FROZEN
PUFF PASTRY (PREFERABLY
PEPPERIDGE FARMS BRAND),
THAWED
2 TABLESPOONS ALL-PURPOSE
FLOUR, PLUS MORE FOR DUSTING
1 TEASPOON KOSHER SALT
GRATED ZEST OF $\frac{1}{2}$ LEMON
 $1\frac{3}{4}$ CUPS HEAVY CREAM

1 LARGE EGG
8 LARGE EGG YOLKS
1 CUP GRANULATED SUGAR
 $\frac{1}{2}$ TEASPOON PURE VANILLA EXTRACT
CONFECTIONERS' SUGAR, FOR
SPRINKLING
GROUND CINNAMON, FOR SPRINKLING

1. Place one still-folded sheet of pastry on a work surface so that a short end is facing you and the thicker fold is to your left. Open the two panels of dough, lightly brush the right panel on both sides with water, and then fold it back into position. Cover with the left panel and press down to seal. Lightly brush the top of the pastry with water, then curl up the short edge and roll up the pastry away from you, as if making a jelly roll. Make sure to keep the spiral very tight. You should have a 3-inch-wide log. Roll it back and forth on the work surface to extend it to $3\frac{1}{2}$ inches. Repeat with the second sheet of pastry. Wrap in plastic and refrigerate.

(recipe continues)

2. Whisk the flour, salt, zest, and $\frac{1}{2}$ cup of the cream in a medium bowl until all the lumps are dissolved. Set aside.
3. Beat the egg and yolks together in a bowl, and set aside.
4. Bring the granulated sugar and $\frac{2}{3}$ cup of water to a boil in a small saucepan over high heat—don't stir—and let it bubble until an instant-read thermometer registers 230°F.
5. Meanwhile, heat the remaining $1\frac{1}{4}$ cups of cream in a medium saucepan over medium-high heat until wisps of steam curl up and bubbles appear around the edges, about 5 minutes.
6. Whisk the hot cream into the flour mixture until smooth, then pour in the hot sugar syrup. Slowly add the egg mixture, whisking continually, then pour the custard back into the medium saucepan and cook over low heat, whisking lazily, until the mixture lightly coats the back of a spoon and registers 170°F on an instant-read thermometer, about 4 minutes. Pour into a bowl, add the vanilla, and let cool completely.
7. Have two muffin tins nearby. Using a serrated knife, trim off the uneven ends of one dough log, sawing in a back-and-forth motion, and discard. Cut twelve $\frac{1}{4}$ -inch slices from the log. Repeat with the remaining log, and refrigerate the slices. Work with only 1 slice at a time. Turn it on its side on a very lightly floured surface. Flatten it into a 3-inch circle with your fingers, and fit it into a well in a muffin tin. Press the dough against the bottom and up the sides, creating a raised lip about $\frac{1}{8}$ inch above the pan, if using a tin with one-third cup capacity (see *Atenção*, page 217). Repeat with the rest of the slices. Prick the shells very well with a fork, and refrigerate the tins for 20 minutes.
8. Position a rack in the middle of the oven, place a baking sheet on the rack, and crank up the heat to 400°F.
9. Fill the tart shells to the top with rice, dried beans, or pie weights. Slip the tins onto the hot baking sheet in the oven (depending on how large your muffin tins are, you may have to bake the pastries in 2 batches) and bake until the edges of the dough are puffed and brown, about 16 minutes. If the pastry starts to color too much, tent the tins loosely with foil. Transfer to a wire rack to cool, leaving the oven on.
10. Empty the rice from the cooled tart shells. Some will stick—no big deal. Use a spoon to gently scrape them out. Fill each shell three-quarters full ($2\frac{1}{2}$ tablespoons) with the cooled custard. Bake until the custards barely jiggle in the middle, about 12 minutes.
11. Transfer the tins to the rack to cool for a few minutes, then pop out the pastries and let cool until warm. Dust with confectioners' sugar and cinnamon.